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Why you cannot play it *fast yet.*

A speed ceiling is a diagnosis, not a verdict. Five causes, the tell that reveals each one in your own playing, and the fix that moves it.

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You cannot play it fast yet because the motion you are repeating is not the motion the tempo needs. A speed ceiling is almost never a talent limit or a rep-count problem. It is one of five things: practicing at a tempo where the motion has already broken down, tension in the fretting or picking hand, the two hands landing at different moments, speeding up a passage that is not yet accurate, and never spending time in the narrow band just below the ceiling. Each has a tell you can check today and a different fix. More of the same practice will not move any of them.

A ceiling is a fact about the motion

Fast playing is the same motion made smaller, timed more exactly, and produced with less effort. Nothing new appears at 160 BPM that was absent at 90; what changes is the tolerance. A finger that travels an inch has time for that at 90 and does not at 160, so a motion that fit before stops fitting and the passage breaks in the same place every time. A ceiling belongs to a motion, not to a player: you might run sixteenths at 130 in one riff and stall at 95 in another.

Why “just play it slow” is incomplete

Slow practice helps only if the slow motion is the same motion, and often it is not. At a comfortable tempo you have time to lift fingers high, press harder than the note needs, re-aim the pick, and gather yourself before the hard bar. None of that fits at speed, and repetition builds whatever you repeat: slow practice full of large motions builds a motion with a low ceiling, and builds it well.

Two questions make slow practice honest.

- **Is this a smaller version of the fast motion, or a different one?**

Fingers stay near the strings, the pick keeps its angle and its short distance, and nothing pauses before the difficult bar. If any of that is untrue, you are rehearsing something that cannot scale.

- **Does the shape survive one step up?** Add a small increase and watch the same list. If the fingers start flying or the wrist locks, the tempo you own is lower than the number you use.

The click is what makes any of this measurable: [practicing guitar with a metronome](#) covers using one honestly, and [how to practice guitar effectively](#) covers the rest of the session.

The five causes, the tell, and the fix

1. You practice at a tempo where the motion is already wrong

The tell. You can name the tempo where it gets messy, and most of your repetitions happen within a few clicks of it, because that is where the passage feels like work.

The fix. Find the tempo you own, as a measurement rather than an opinion: three passes in a row, cold, at the start of a session, no missed notes, no rushing, no mid-phrase recovery. A pass you saved is not a clean pass. Whatever survives is the bottom of your ladder, normally well below the number you called your tempo.

2. You are holding tension you cannot feel

Speed is the rate at which a motion can reverse. A finger pressing harder than the note needs has to stop pressing before it can leave; a locked hand has to be overcome before the pick can change direction. Tension caps how fast a motion turns around, and it accumulates.

The tells.

- The forearm burns or the hand cramps within half a minute.

- The pick rotates in your fingers, or you regrip between phrases.
- Passes get worse across a set instead of better. Technique does not degrade over five repetitions; tension does.
- The note *after* the difficult bit lands late even though the difficult bit worked.

The fix. Find your pressure floor: fret a note, release until it buzzes, add back the least pressure that clears it, and play there. Drop the volume too, since loud playing recruits tension in both hands. Scan where you have attention to spare: jaw, shoulder, fretting thumb, pick grip, breath. And end a repetition when the tension arrives rather than pushing to the end of the bar. Pushing through is a repetition of playing tense.

3. Your hands are not landing together

Each hand can be individually competent and jointly wrong. At a low tempo the window for arriving together is wide enough that nobody notices the gap; as the tempo climbs the window narrows and the gap does not. The sound is not wrong notes but a smear: the tail of the previous note under the new attack, or a muted click where the pick beat the finger.

The tells.

- Slowly, every note is right. Fast, it is sloppy, and you cannot name which note is wrong.
- It is acceptable clean and unusable with gain. Distortion amplifies what happens between notes, which is where a sync problem lives.
- Picked passages break down while legato ones survive, or the reverse. The failure is in the join.

The fix is to take the hands apart at the tempo you want, then rejoin them below it. Mute the strings and play the picking pattern alone at the target tempo: if it is uneven there, the problem is the pattern, not the sync. Then play the passage with no pick, hammering every note: if it is uneven here, the fretting hand is out of time. Put them together slowly enough to hear each attack separately. The tempo where you can hear the seam is where you can close it.

One more test: start the passage on an upstroke. If it works one way and collapses the other, the pick direction was never decided. Where the join is between chord shapes, Strumly's guide to [smoother chord transitions](#) covers what the hands have to agree on.

4. The passage is not accurate yet

Speed does not produce accuracy. It removes the time you were quietly using to correct.

The tell, and the most useful one here: watch *where* the errors land across four or five passes. A failure in the same place every time is a mechanical problem at that spot, and one of the three causes above will name it. A failure that moves means the passage is not learned yet. The two feel identical from inside the room and need different weeks.

A second tell: you cannot say out loud which finger plays each note, where the shift happens, and which way each pick stroke goes. A passage that was never decided cannot be made automatic, because you play a slightly different one every time.

The fix. Decide it — position, fingering, shift points, pick direction — and leave it alone for the week. Then take one pass at the comfortable tempo, no run-up. If you miss, the passage is still under construction, and that is this week's work.

5. You never spend time just under the ceiling

Two habits produce this and they look like opposites: living at the ceiling and nowhere else, so every repetition is a repetition of the passage failing, or living well below it and trying the song tempo once at the end of a session to see whether it has arrived.

Both leave the same range empty, and that range does the work: from a few rungs under your best clean tempo up to it. Fast enough that the motion has to become efficient, slow enough that it stays correct.

The tell. Your metronome has two numbers in it, the safe one and the song's one, and nothing between them has had a session of its own.

The fix. Put most of a session's tempo work inside that band, and move its top one rung at a time. Which is what a ladder is.

The climb: capped steps, holds, and back-offs

A tempo ladder is the ordered set of tempos between the speed you own and the speed you want, one session per rung. The parts that are not a straight line are what make it hold.

- **The first rung is a measurement, not practice.** You are finding the fastest tempo you can play the passage three times cleanly in a row, cold. Start above it and every later rung is a guess.
- **Steps are capped, not averaged.** No rung asks for more than about a tenth of the tempo you are leaving, and never more than 10 BPM, because hands feel proportion rather than arithmetic.
- **Some rungs repeat the previous tempo.** Reaching a tempo once and owning it are different skills, and the second comes only from repetitions at a speed you reached.
- **One ladder per passage, not per song.** Three spots holding a song back is three ladders.

What a back-off rep is for

At least one session goes down on purpose. A back-off drops below the top tempo you reached and climbs back through the rungs you passed, inside one sitting. Three things happen there that a straight climb cannot produce.

- **It finds the rung you skipped.** A ladder climbed once leaves rungs you reached and never owned. Walking back up exposes the one that fails, and that tempo is what the next session works on.
- **It turns a ceiling into a floor.** A number you hit once, on a good day, after warming up, is a ceiling. A number you can arrive at from below, cold, is a floor, and the floor is what shows up when someone is listening.
- **It removes the incentive to protect the number.** Once the top tempo is something you re-earn, there is nothing to defend, and the quiet edits stop: the simplified voicing, the dropped note, the generous definition of clean.

The [tempo ladder builder](#) writes that sequence out: enter the tempo you already play cleanly and the tempo you want, choose how many sessions to spend, and it returns the rungs in order with a pass condition on each. Where those sessions sit in a week is a separate question, and Strumly's guide to [designing a practice routine](#) covers it.

Two checks before you commit a month

Count the recording against a metronome instead of trusting the number in your head; chasing a tempo the record never played is an avoidable way to fail. And check that you are playing the same part, because fast playing on records is often the easy version: an open string where you are shifting, hammer-ons where you are picking every note.

What to do this week

1. Pick one passage, not a song: the bar or two that breaks, plus a beat either side. Measure its baseline cold, first thing in a session, and write the number down.
2. Run the tells. Do the errors sit in one place or move? Is the fifth pass worse than the first? Does the picking pattern hold on muted strings?
3. Build the ladder from that baseline to a target you can reach this month, not automatically the tempo on the record.
4. At the end, record one pass at the top tempo against a recording made today. That comparison is the evidence.

If nothing in your playing has moved for months, rather than this one passage, start with [why guitar practice plateaus](#). If you are not sure which it is, the [practice plateau diagnostic](#) ends with a named blocker.

GuitarHub Field Guide No. 09. The latest version of this guide, with its tools and links, lives at guitarhub.org/why-cant-i-play-guitar-fast.